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002C — Petrarch: Antiquity, Eloquence, and the Present

Prose and sonnet seminar · 2026–27

Reading: 002C1 — introduction and prose on printed pp. 293–294, stopping before Leonardo Bruni; Canzoniere 310 and its notes on packet p. 3. Read and discuss both the prose and the sonnet today.

MEETING E002.3 — Friday 10/16 | Antiquity, eloquence, and voice

AIM: How does Petrarch express his judgments and feelings in prose and poetry?

GOALS: Explain what Petrarch values in classical learning; analyze his imagery; explain the sonnet's turn from spring to personal grief.

DO NOW — E002.3: From Pico to Petrarch

Without notes: In one sentence, state what Pico thought human beings could make of themselves. Then read Petrarch's opening words, "O inglorious age!" What might Petrarch think people should do with that human capacity?

Pico thought humans could make whatever they wanted of themselves. no limits, could be like animal or like God

HOMEWORK CHECK: Open the introduction, prose, annotated sonnet, and four answers. Compare answers briefly before discussion.

PETRARCH — BACKGROUND

Petrarch (d. 1374; Proto-Renaissance) is considered to be "the first man of letters." He lived a generation after Dante.

In 1345, he discovered a collection of Cicero's letters that had been lost.

He was religious and also a great lover of life, building on the Roman Cicero and the Christian (and late Roman) Augustine. Again, we see how the Renaissance is mixing Christian and Roman ideas. He wrote a great deal—both in terms of poetry and prose.

Petrarch didn't invent the sonnet form but popularized it. The sonnet is a very specific poem with a structure of 14 lines. This form would become one of the most famous forms of poetry—used by Shakespeare, Keats, and many others.



GROUP DISCUSSION — Every group answers its PROSE question(s) and its SONNET question below. Begin with your completed homework. Prepare one short quotation from each text, then lead the class on your follow-up. Everyone in the group speaks. Jot notes; write the two-sentence summary at the end.

GROUP 1 — Nathan, David, Simon

PROSE — Questions 1–2

1. Educated critics. Why does Petrarch judge "men of education" more harshly than "the vulgar"? What responsibility comes with their education?

2. Ancient models. Name three ancient writers Petrarch praises or defends. What quality of their writing or learning does he want his contemporaries to recover?

SONNET — Lines 1–8. Choose Zephyr, Aphrodite or Jove. How does this classical figure help Petrarch describe spring? Use a line from the poem and the notes.

ASK THE CLASS: Is Petrarch angry because the critics disagree with ancient writers, or because they dismiss writers they do not understand?

GROUP 2 — Naomi, Sam

PROSE — Question 3

3. Language and formation. On p. 294, Petrarch calls his opponents "innocent of knowledge and virtue." What two failures does he connect? Use this phrase and one named ancient writer to explain the kind of learning he values.

SONNET — Lines 9–14. What does "Who bore its hopes and pangs to Paradise!" tell us about the absent woman, and why does the speaker still sigh?

ASK THE CLASS: Does "Paradise" remove the speaker's grief? Which words support your answer?

GROUP 3 — Ari, Aylin

PROSE — Question 4

4. Rhetorical force. Why call Cicero the "bright sun of eloquence" while describing the critics as ants that "devastate the fields of sound learning"? What contrast between their effects on learning does he create?

SONNET — Lines 1–14. Why do "birds and flowers and woman's graces mild" become "a desert, stern and wild" for the speaker? Use a spring image and a phrase from lines 9–14.

ASK THE CLASS: Has spring itself changed, or has its meaning changed for the speaker? Which words decide this?

GROUP 4 — Jane, Daniel, Jack

PROSE — Question 5

5. The individual voice. What does the passage reveal about Petrarch himself—his tastes, frustrations, or intellectual ambitions? Use one first-person phrase or emotionally charged phrase as evidence.

"I Certainly am not a Ciceronian or a Platonist but a Christian." This quote shows that he appriciates old texts/writers but doesn't change religion views.

SONNET — Lines 8–14. What changes at "For me, alas!"? How do "For me" and "To me" distinguish the speaker from "every creature" in line 8?

he gets into his own point of view (creatures, not Gods.

ASK THE CLASS: Why say "every creature" immediately before "For me"?

WRITING PRACTICE — NOTES → SENTENCES

In note form, record: one prose accusation | one spring image | one phrase showing the speaker's feelings. Then write two sentences: Sentence 1 explains Petrarch's criticism and what he values in classical learning. Sentence 2 explains why he experiences spring differently from "every creature."

HOMEWORK: For Monday 10/19: Reread Canzoniere 310 and your annotations on p. 3 of 002C1 (also printed in 002D). Be ready to explain one annotation in light of today's discussion. Bring the Petrarch packet and your four homework answers again. Also complete the assigned history homework.